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Five Nights at Freddy's: The Evolution of a Narrative

Five Nights at Freddy's (FNAF) is a popular indie horror game based on the idea of haunted animatronics roaming around entertainment venues. What began as a simple and unique survival horror quickly transformed into one of the most complicated narrative games of today. The gameplay and story gradually changed over time, from being cryptic and simple to a multimedia story line.

The first FNAF game was mainly focused on surviving the night. The mechanics were simple. Check the security cameras, conserve power and shut the doors if any animatronic are nearby. The goal was to make it to 6 AM for a minimum of five nights. The narrative was minimal and only told through phone calls the player received at the beginning of each night and newspaper clippings that are scattered in the game. The story was never directly told but needed to be pieced together. This cryptic style became the games defining feature and forced players to interpret the narrative themselves.

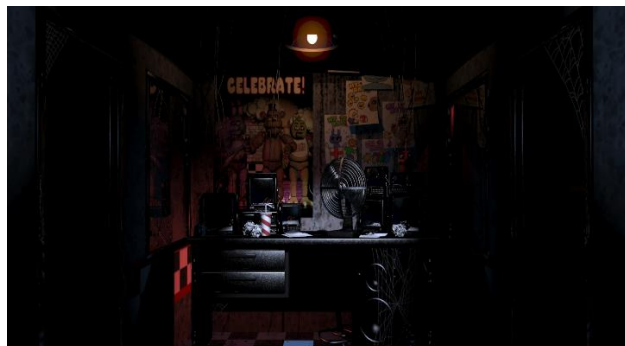


Figure 1: FNAF 1 office

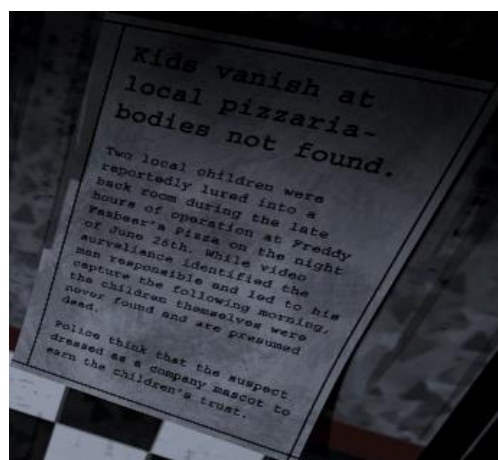


Figure 2: Newspaper clipping that randomly appears on camera

During the middle era, from games 1 to 4, FNAF started to expand on how they told the story and how players discovered the lore. The core gameplay still relied on watching the cameras, but each sequel had unique survival mechanics and systems that kept gameplay fresh and intense. Mini games, cutscenes and recurring characters allowed the community to piece together a timeline across games. FNAF became known for its seamless blend of gameplay and storytelling, and how it hid important details in secret mini games and cutscenes that were fragmented across the multiple games. It became a community effort to solve the mystery of Five Nights at Freddy's, with many reddit posts and popular theory channels chiming in on their ideas.

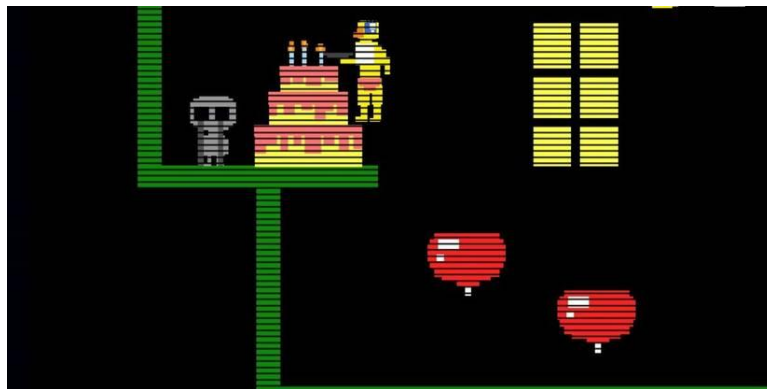


Figure 3: Mini game from FNAF 2



Figure 4: Cutscene from FNAF 4

Five Nights at Freddy's: Sister Location was the start of a more narrative era. Gameplay was more linear and task-based, instead of staying in a single room. Unlike the previous games where players had to survive until 6 AM, players survived by following the instructions. The story was presented more directly from the character, Baby, who both guided and misled the player. The story is still cryptic as it now introduced a new level of information that had to fit into the timeline. The story also introduced the main villain, William Afton, who acted as the narrative anchor, as the story became more connected to his character.



Figure 5: Sister Location gameplay

The narrative started to use multiple media to expand its story. Many novels were written, hints were hidden in guidebooks, and key information was stored in the HTML source code of one of the websites. For example, the Survival Logbook contained the name of a recurring character, Golden Freddy, and was solved by using modified page numbers as coordinates in a word search.[2] The books started to overlap with the main story and were labelled as canon adjacent. The decision to expand the narrative in many forms of media took storytelling to new levels but made the lore difficult to keep up with as it didn't stay within the game boundaries and had to be sought out.



Figure 6: Survival Logbook

The modern era of FNAF, which takes place after Five Nights at Freddy's: Help Wanted, shifted the series once again. Games became more open-world and cinematic, focusing on exploration, stealth and puzzle solving. Players feel less helpless as they can actively defend themselves. Characters had more dialogue, making the story direct. Cryptic clues were still hidden in secret mini-games, but it felt less rewarding as discovering them took time due to the large open-world design of taking place in a mall complex. It removed the high-stake tension of being claustrophobic and confined, and replaced it the stress of being hunted throughout the mall. [3] With the expansion of the game, came the expansion of story.

However, the narrative not only expanded over the games, but also found its place in books and multiple endings, which made the story convoluted and increasingly difficult to follow. It didn't help that the story itself has been changed by the original game developer, Scott Cawthon. This made the narrative more confusing and difficult to piece together. [4]



Figure 7: Security Breach Gameplay

The evolution of FNAF reflects how gameplay and story telling can evolve over time. The earlier games relied on mystery and player interpretation, while later sequels focused on direct storytelling and expanding a narrative. Although the series has strayed away from its cryptic roots, there is still a story for the player to uncover.